

weekend

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RACING TO THE PEAK

Meet the runners tackling Ladakh's high-altitude challenge P2

metroPLUS THE HINDU

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In November 2025, Vikram Narula, founder of Ajwain Watches, received a call from the Indian Air Force about developing a watch. The Air Force had prepared a preliminary design and approached other Indian watch companies, but were not impressed with their designs. Vikram suggested changes and met Chief of the Air Staff, Air Chief Marshal Amar Preet Singh and finalised the project.

The resulting watch was IAF Kshitij. A Grade 5 titanium case was shaped to evoke the afterburner of a fighter jet, while an internal rotating world-time bezel and GMT movement replaced the conventional three-hand configuration. India's GMT+5:30 position was marked with the tricolour. The watch was conceived as a formal gift that the Air Chief could present to counterparts abroad, rather than as an instrument for pilots in the cockpit. A civilian edition is now being planned (its price is undecided), and it will launch next month.

The commission points to a larger shift in India's watch market. Microbrands selling watches from about ₹1,500 to ₹50,000 and above, are finding buyers through small-batch production, imported movements, and designs rooted in Indian histories. What are these young brands getting right, why are collectors buying them, and can this momentum grow into a durable Indian watchmaking ecosystem?

The Indian touch

Watch collector Manu Srikumar, based in Kochi, whose collection includes more than 100 vintage watches and over 70 HMTs, argues that 'Made in India' is too simple a description for much of the microbrand ecosystem. "India does not yet have a manufacturing base capable of producing every component, particularly movements, so brands frequently source internationally while designing and assembling watches here."

For instance, IAF Kshitij's titanium case had to be manufactured overseas since Indian manufacturers could not produce it to specification. The final watch brings together components sourced from different manufacturers before assembly.

"The movement inside the watch may be Japanese, Swiss, or manufactured elsewhere, but the design is increasingly Indian. One takes inspiration from a city, or a local festival," says Manu.

Micro to luxury

Jaipur Watch Company, founded by Gaurav Mehta in 2013, began by placing one-anna, 50-paise and one-rupee coins into dials before moving into postage stamps and hand-painted Pichwai and filigree motifs. Its Raja Ravi Varma collection translated 14 oleographs, including *Hans Damayanti*, *Birth of Shakuntala* and *Radha in the Moonlight*, onto the wrist, while its Baagh series incorporates a 1947 one-rupee coin bearing a walking tiger. The company has a watch that has Swami Vivekananda's letter written to Sister Nivedita

(Clockwise from right) The Waqt edition from Avarth; caseback of Coromandel Watch Company's Kaapi watch; Avarth's Chandni edition; dial and coffee bean lume of the Kaapi watch. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



The movement inside the watch may be Japanese, Swiss, or manufactured elsewhere, but the design is increasingly Indian. One takes inspiration from a city, or a local festival.

MANU SRIKUMAR,
Watch collector

clicking bezel, water resistance, sapphire crystal and lume completed the appeal.

His second purchase, Muhurto's ₹1,400 Bhim Nag-inspired watch took him back to childhood Durga Pujas, when he would go pandal-hopping with his father and sometimes stop at Bhim Chandra Nag, where his attention would settle on the old clock. One watch was bought with the collector's eye for specifications; the other with memory.

Manu believes watches are reaching buyers beyond collectors. Delhi Watch Company's Terra is his clearest example. "It has been appreciated globally, it is distinctive, and priced at ₹4,500, affordable to a much larger audience," he says.

Among the brands he considers significant are Kala Watch Company and Sebastian Watch Company.

"Sebastian Watch Company uses HMT cases and movements, but create their own custom dials inspired by Meenakari and Rajasthani art."

Watches for women

Sanjana Sarma, who founded Avarth with Sharan Mukund In January 2026 says, "Women collectors want a moonphase, a day-date and lume. They want cool and unusual watches too."

Watches designed specifically for women and smaller wrists remain relatively scarce. Vikram attributes this largely to economics: men still make up a bigger proportion of collectors, so young brands with limited capital tend to invest more heavily in men's lines.

Avarth approached the market with Chandni, a smaller watch with Devanagari numerals and lotus motifs. Its first drop sold out in three days.

Bangalore Watch Company's ₹1.2 lakh *The 1947* is an ode to a generation that inherited the consequences of colonial rule but chose to invest in institutions, education and nation-building.

Avarth will launch *Gandaberunda* in October. Named after the two-headed bird associated with Mysore's Wadiyar dynasty and now Karnataka's State emblem. Its price is yet to be decided.

Future of Indian microbrands

Gaurav singles out Delhi Watch Company for its design and innovation, but argues, "the moment premiumisation starts, many may not sustain unless they evolve. You cannot just sell Devanagari numerals on every dial. By printing the numerals, you don't become Indian. You have to add something more."

Indian Standard Time

Young Indian watch brands are drawing on art, history, home and memory to create distinctive, collectable watches — giving buyers a more personal alternative to conventional luxury, often at more accessible prices

engraved on its dial. It is also one of the few brands to have an extensive women's line including an intricate elephant ring watch. Ed Sheeran wore their Devanagari Baagh watch, while Prime Minister Narendra Modi has been spotted wearing the 1947-coin Roman Baagh. After 13 years in the industry, Gaurav observes, "India has 150 crore people, which means 150 crore wrists. Our market size is our strength. It is growing by around 20-30% per year. What you need is honest positioning."

India on the dial

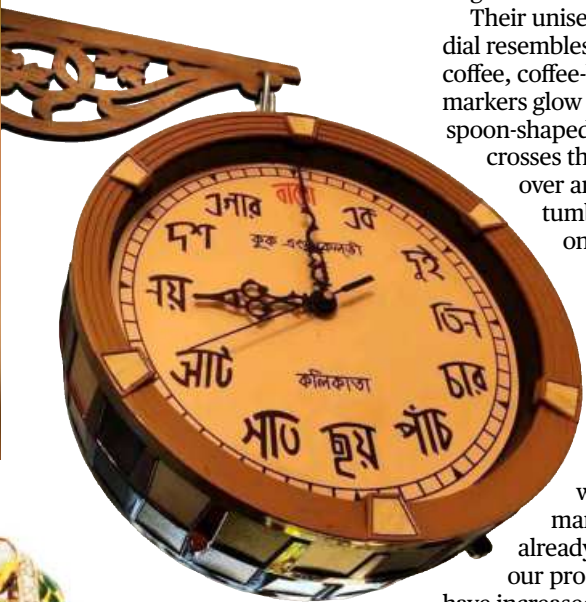
In Bengal, Muhurto began in 2025 with the large Cooke & Kelvey clock with Bengali numerals at Bhim Chandra Nag in Bowbazar. Founder Kiran Baidya remembers visiting the sweet shop with her husband and co-founder Subhajit Parui, who wished for a wristwatch modelled on the clock. Producing one or two pieces was unviable, so Kiran showed the design to customers of their book business. All 100 were pre-booked within two or three days.

That first watch has since expanded into a catalogue that treats the dial as a miniature archive of Bengal. *Nayak*, dedicated to actor Uttam Kumar on his birth centenary, draws on Satyajit Ray's calligraphy; *Rabindrik* references Abanindranath Tagore's portrait of



Rabindranath as a Baul; *Azad Hind* combines Netaji's envisioned map of India, the INA tiger and his Bengali signature; *Amitrakshar* draws on a rare letter by Michael Madhusudan Dutt; while *Bharat Mata* adapts Abanindranath's painting and one of his alpina motifs. "Through every watch, we try to represent the art, culture, history and pride of Bengal," says Kiran.

Further south, Coromandel Watch Company's Blue Mountain Edition is an ode to the Nilgiri Mountain Railway. Founded by Amit Sudevan and



(Clockwise from left) An elephant ring watch from Jaipur Watch Company; The Blue Mountain edition by Coromandel Watch Company; Avanti by Avarth; Muhurto's Bhim Nag watch. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Shibin V.S.in 2024, the train is a part of Shibin's commute between Coonoor and Ooty. Its Blue Mountain Edition turns that familiarity into colour: red, yellow and blue recall the train, while white, brown, black and green draw from the clouds, soil, darker mountain landscape and forests of the Nilgiris.

Their unisex Kaappi watch's dial resembles freshly ground coffee, coffee-bean hour markers glow with lume, a spoon-shaped seconds hand crosses the face. Turn it over and a davara and tumbler are engraved on the caseback.

Shibin says, "These are things we could not do when we started because R&D was expensive and we had to work with what manufacturers already had. Now that our production numbers have increased, we can bring much more of our own vision into the watch."

What are people buying?

In one month, sports journalist Santadeep Dey bought two Indian microbrand watches for contrasting reasons. The first was Delhi Watch Company's Havelock priced at ₹11,000. Its Gradient Aqua dial, which changes appearance in different light, initially caught his attention; the polished bracelet,

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The newly inaugurated Cheenapara Heritage Gallery sits on Kolkata's Blackburn Lane alongside the hum of Central Avenue, in the deep folds of Tiretta Bazaar. It shares a wall with the old Chinese restaurant Sei Vui.

Inside, under warm yellow lights, objects from Kolkata's Chinese past fill the rooms. Outside, September rain draws a grey curtain across the afternoon.

Between the two is a portrait, more than five feet tall, of Sun Yat-sen – physician, revolutionary and founder of the Republic of China after whom a street near Tiretta Bazaar's Poddar Court is named.

On September 5, the glass over his portrait caught the shifting reflections of visitors and members of Kolkata's Chinese community as they moved through the gallery. In this old Chinatown, where a community's history survives in street names, restaurants, and memory, the image was difficult to miss: the present moving across the face of the past.

Spearheaded by the CHA Project, a Singapore-based design studio and INTACH's Calcutta Chapter, the gallery brings together tools of trade, artefacts and a visual archive of the city's Chinese community. GM Kapur, head of INTACH's Kolkata chapter, says the idea was conceived nearly a decade ago with Rinkoo Bhowmik, founder of The CHA Project, and took shape over the years with historian Tansen Sen's involvement. The project was sponsored by Sei Vui Club, The British Academy, NYU Shanghai Boost Fund, Center for Global Asia at NYU Shanghai, and Pou Chong Companies and Products.

A building that remembers

The building had been holding memories long before it became a gallery. At 17 Blackburn Lane stands the Huining Huiguan, a guild hall and temple established in 1908 by Chinese migrants from Sihui, or Sei Vui, and neighbouring Guangning in Guangdong province. Its name brings the two ancestral places together.

Tansen Sen, professor of History and director, Centre for Global Asia at NYU Shanghai, believes the building itself explains why Tiretta Bazaar cannot be reduced to the convenient phrase 'old Chinatown'. The temple inside is linked to a religious tradition associated with a particular part of Guangdong and is unlike other Chinese temples in India. "The Huining Huiguan used to be a club where people who



A Chinese despatch

Inside a century-old community hall on Blackburn Lane, Kolkata's new Cheenapara Heritage Gallery brings the city's Chinese past to life



migrated from the Guangdong region stayed. Sei Vui is the place where the Chinese migrants who built this place came from," says the professor. Looking ahead to 2028, when Kolkata marks 250 years of its association with the Chinese community, Tansen says that the aim is to create a similar gallery in Tangra's Chinatown.

The history of the community

survives in wooden chairs, vases, cymbals, incense sticks, sauce bottles, mahjong sets, abacuses, tools used by people who worked with their hands and built their lives in Kolkata. "The exhibition looks at the multiple waves of migration through the 1800s and then moves into economic specialisation. Different Chinese communities that came to the city began specialising

in particular trades," says Sohini Pyne, who designed and curated the exhibition. Those trades gave Chinese Calcutta a distinct economic geography.

Cantonese migrants became closely associated with carpentry. Hakka families with shoemaking and, later, the tanneries of Tangra. Migrants from Hubei with dentistry. Those from Shandong with the silk trade. Laundries, beauty parlours and restaurants cut across some of these divisions.

Finding a place in the city

Tansen hopes the Blackburn Lane gallery will eventually become one chapter in a larger archive scattered across Kolkata. There are about seven such associations, he says, each carrying a different history. Tangra tells another story one of tanneries, leather and restaurants, shaped particularly by its Hakka community.

Kolkata's Chinese history is commonly traced to Yang Dazhao, better known as Atchew, the Chinese trader who received land near Budge Budge from Warren Hastings in 1778. He established a sugar mill there and brought Chinese workers to Bengal. The settlement that grew around it became Achipur.

Research, however, indicates that the Chinese were already present in Bengal before Atchew. The familiar description of him as the first Chinese settler is therefore more complicated than it first appears. Successive migrations created a community that, by the middle of the 20th Century, was woven into the working life of Calcutta.

Then came 1962. The India-China war tore through much of this social and economic world. Chinese Indians were interned or deported. Dockworkers lost jobs on security grounds. Businesses closed. Many families later left India for North



(Clockwise from left) A Chinese vase; a Chinese shop at Tiretta Bazaar; street view of the Bazaar; Tansen Sen speaking to gallery visitors; entrance to the gallery; and an old donation record book. BUJOY CHOUDHURY; AGNIBHA CHOUDHURY

America, Europe, Australia and elsewhere.

Restaurateur Miranda Liu, whose family is associated with Beijing and Tung Fong, remembers the period as the beginning of the great thinning out. Families left in search of work and security. Today, Miranda estimates Kolkata's Chinese population at roughly 2,000.

A neighbourhood still alive

Sohini hopes the gallery will prompt other communities to look at what they have inherited before the objects, and the stories attached to them, disappear.

The final section moves between festivals and ordinary life: streets, people and moments in Cheenapara recorded across decades. Chen



The gallery will be open to the public on Sundays from 8am to noon.

Five runners share their training strategies, race-day lessons and tips for tackling the Ladakh Marathon's high-altitude races, from the marathon in Leh to the Khardung La Challenge and Silk Route Ultra at elevations of up to 17,982 feet

Oliver Jones, Bengaluru



Marathon in 2025.

This year, he and his partner have registered for the 72-km Khardung La Challenge, training for the event by incorporating hill running and hypoxic training in swimming pools. They also work out in their home gym three days a week, focusing especially on lower body strengthening, says Oliver, who thinks of this race as "the ultimate conclusion, when you start racing in India"

Namghyal Lhamo, Ladakh

Namghyal Lhamo has an advantage: she comes from the village of Domkhar Gongma in Ladakh, about 120 km from Leh, and is more accustomed to the region's thinner air. "We, too, struggle with breathing a little bit, but it is not as bad as for people from outside Ladakh," she says. While she ran in school and won contests, her first marathon was in 2014 in Ladakh, says Namghyal, an SPO with the Ladakh Police force. She went on to complete many other marathons, then shifted to ultras in 2022, participating in and winning the Khardong La Challenge four times in a row. Now, for the first time, she is embarking on the Silk Route



Runner's high

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Cheewang Motup Goba, the man behind the Ladakh Marathon, which kicked off on September 10, is delighted with its evolution. "After 13 editions, seeing runners from 28 countries and six continents, and from almost every part of India, is something we can be proud of," he says of the run, which comprise six major races of varying lengths, including the 122-km Silk Route Ultra and the 72-km Khardung La Challenge.

We ask five participants, at different stages of their running journeys, what has brought them to this moment.



Sufiya Sufi, Manali

Sufiya Sufi is still on a high from her recent running achievement: a 5000-km-long stretch between Kanyakumari and the Karakoram pass, which she completed earlier this year, in 86 days and 2 hours. "I have not fully recovered, but the 122-km-long Silk Route run is very close to my heart," says the multiple Guinness World Record holder, one of India's most well-known endurance athletes. Having attended the Ladakh Marathon for over five years now, she knows that running in the mountains is very different from the plains. "You have to be there for long and train there as much as possible," says Sufiya, who began her running journey in 2017, after her job started affecting her health. "I started running three km for fitness, and then it became my passion," she says. When she trains for a particular event, she mostly focuses on rehab, functional exercises, and meditation rather than mileage, says Sufiya, the winner of the Silk Route run last year. "Ladakh is my favourite place to run. It not only a marathon but a festival for everyone."



Sparsh Jain, New Delhi

As a former cricketer, running was always a key part of Sparsh Jain's training routine. "Earlier, it just used to be a 10- 12 km run for fitness; I never worried about pace or time," he says. Then, in 2023, after completing his first half-marathon, he started taking interest in running events, mostly half or full marathons, before falling in love with the idea of ultra-races, any footrace exceeding the traditional marathon distance of 42 km. "I knew I had to feel it myself once," says the Delhi-based business owner, who went on to complete two different ultras in Ladakh: the Khardung La Challenge in 2024 and the Silk Route Ultra in 2025. Now, he is all set to do the Khardung La Challenge again, says Sparsh, who has been training hard for it. His biggest learning from his previous experience is this: stay humble. "There are times when you feel like you've done a lot and can do anything. But when you come back here, you realise that, no, there is still a lot to do," says Sparsh.

Dr Lakshmi Roopesh, Bengaluru

When Dr Lakshmi Roopesh began running, back in 2017, "I could not even run 100 meters," says the Bengaluru-based dentist. She has come a long way since then, with several half and full marathons and even a couple of ultras of around 50 km under her belt. This year, for the first time, she will be trying to run 72 km, as part of the Khardung La Challenge at the Ladakh Marathon. "It is not just a run, but a challenge," says Dr Lakshmi, who has done both a half and a full marathon in Ladakh already. But as someone who has dreamed of doing it since 2023, she has done everything possible to succeed, working hard on her nutrition and training. Now, she is most looking forward to what the mountains will teach her on this journey. "They have their own way of telling you things about life," she says



Hindi

Taapsee Pannu hits a blind spot



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Mardaani meets Mom in a mythical framework as Taapsee Pannu joins hands with writer-producer Kanika Dhillon to open a new pulpy chapter after Haseen Dillruba. Invoking the divine wrath of the Devi to anchor a meaningful action-thriller, Gandhari attempts to subvert the typical Bollywood revenge trope, but it ends up more intellectually burdened than artistically elevated.

Set in the fictional town of Joypurra, the narrative traces a mother's harrowing journey after her young daughter is abducted from a crowded railway station. Left temporarily blind after a brutal attack, Bani (Taapsee) transforms into a force of vengeance against a sinister child-trafficking ring.

It tries to bring together director Devashish Makhija's realistic, socio-political minimalism and Kanika's commercial feminist template. However, as it turns out, it is bereft of tonal identity. Instead of finding a middle ground, Gandhari feels like a movie where the director and the writer are fighting for control of the steering wheel.

The integration of ancient goddess-and-demon lore feels forced, and it muddles the gritty realism of the child-trafficking plot the film seeks to sell. The mythic parallel functions more as a superficial cover that constantly breaks the audience's immersion.

Moreover, when a thriller hinges on a major twist or a hidden reveal about its protagonist, that hidden layer must act as the missing puzzle piece that recontextualises everything we have already seen. Here, the present is not palatable, and the reveal about Bani's past feels more like a throwaway trick than organic narrative evolution.

The storytelling oscillates between a moody indie and a loud, mainstream revenge potboiler. Monologue-heavy confrontations often puncture scenes that require quiet, agonising grief, making the trauma feel distant and the obstacles contrived. The writing relies heavily on a formula in which the female protagonist must emerge as an untouchable, larger-than-life force of nature. The vulnerability is only skin deep. We rarely feel Bani is in actual, fatal danger.

While Tapsee is undeniably efficient as a defiant mother, the performance offers little artistic surprise because we have already seen her navigate a similar emotional and physical landscape in Blurr and Dobaara. More importantly, the visual and auditory choices don't serve the intent. They rather pander to a curated, algorithm-friendly streaming palette. The dialect comes and goes, but when Punjabi lyrics play in the background of action unfolding in a Bengali neighborhood, the jarring pop choice shatters any sense of place. Ultimately, Gandhari is consumed by its own contradictions.

Gandhari is currently streaming on Netflix



New beast, same pulse

In the cinematic transition of the OTT series, director Gurmeet Singh and writer Puneet Krishna get the mood and moments right but flatten the political nuance

Hindi

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There is an old saying in the film trade that in Indian cinema, audiences can forgive a weaker plot if they fall in love with the people inhabiting it. Much like Ramesh Sippy's Sholay and Aditya Dhar's Dhurandhar, the plot of Gurmeet Singh's Mirzapur is ultimately just scaffolding; the characters are the architecture, and the dialogues lend it vibrant color. You don't merely watch the characters, you develop a deeply personal, at times toxic, yet fiercely loyal bond with them. The plot occasionally wanders into generic gang-war territory, but we stay glued because of Akhanadand Tripathi, aka Kaleen Bhaiya's (Pankaj Tripathi) cold pauses and crisp one-liners, Munna's tragic yet explosive desperation for love, winsome Guddu's (Ali Fazal) terrifying, unpredictable rage, and Bablu's (Jitendra Kumar) is not as effective as Vikrant Massey's dilemma between a book and a gun.

Munna and Guddu are on different sides of the social divide, but they mirror each other. Both seek their father's approval, and both fight for what was denied to their mothers. They are psychological twins born on opposite sides of a broken socio-political fence. Much like the charismatic Jai, Veeru, and Gabbar, these are characters who have broken bones and the law. Yet, the writing humanises their moral decay so effectively that you gladly step into the grey zone with them and find yourself rooting for competing factions at once.

Opening a cinematic chapter somewhere in the middle of the first season of the series, Gurmeet unleashes a different beast that retains the defining characteristics of its parent. Within the initial ten minutes, the screenplay sheds

Mirzapur The Movie

Director: Gurmeet Singh

Duration: 197 minutes

Cast: Pankaj Tripathi, Ali Fazal, Divyendu, Ravi Kishan, Jitendra Kumar, Rasika Dugal, Shriya Pilgaonkar, Shweta Tripathi, Sheeba Chaddha, Kulbhushan Kharbanda, Abhishek Banerjee, Rajesh Tailang.

Synopsis: The film chronicles a fierce struggle between bahubalis and their political masters for absolute supremacy over the Purvanchal underworld.



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its episodic skin, and the tonal shift from an OTT series to a feature film doesn't feel jarring. Relying on the audience to connect the dots to the source material, writer Puneet Krishna ensures the characters' core motivations—why someone is doing what they are doing—are never lost in transition. In fact, some character insights are spelled out more clearly. For instance, the role of Guddu's mother, Vasudha Pandit (Sheeba Chaddha), in his psychological transformation into a gangster is clearer. Similarly, it deepens Beena Tripathi's (Rasika Dugal) survival trajectory among the Tripathi men and the scars behind Munna's (Divyendu) misplaced machismo. While the men in Mirzapur are trapped in a cycle of destructive, often predictable machismo, the women drive the plot's real undercurrents.

Sanitising the narrative for a wider theatrical audience, Puneet cuts down on the profanity and overt sexual politics that defined the OTT series. This restraint does not dilute the film's impact. Instead, it sharpens it as he embellishes the narrative with potent metaphors of the heartland. Drenched in rustic wit, the dialogues function as a high-stakes psychological game. The spoken word sounds humorous but instantly becomes a matter of life and death. The cinematic format amplifies the pregnant pauses and the low, menacing whispers of Kaleen Bhaiya in the theatre, leaving the audience hanging on every word, for a single verbal misstep can trigger a bloodbath.

As for the world-building, perhaps the most politically telling aspect of the film is its deliberate restructuring of Purvanchal's criminal landscape. Driven by what appears to be current political expediency, the makers ground the narrative within a specific historical window of Uttar Pradesh's political timeline, completely bypassing the Muslim and Thakur ganglords of the region. Instead, the film seems to reframe the entire power struggle as a Yadav vs.

Brahmin war for absolute supremacy in Purvanchal politics. The OBC group represents the political class, while the upper-caste group leads the underworld. If one wants patronage, the other seeks funds. The film doesn't explore what the Yadav party's political rivals are up to when it patronises one section of Bahubalis. While the series largely balanced the representation of different caste groups, the film flattens it as sophisticated feudalism versus crude, power-hungry interlopers.

Integrating actor-politician Ravi Kishan into the Mirzapur universe brings the required colour, meta-context and political patronage in a State that is, of late, very conscious of its image on screen. As a kind of feminist Bahubali, Ravi embodies the region's posture and linguistic rhythm with inimitable, chameleonic flair. Pramod Pathak matches him as an opportunistic, sleazy politician.

Once again, Pankaj Tripathi as Akhanda emerges as the lifeline. He lives the written word and the subtext, navigating a complex emotional matrix where dominance and fear, lobh (desire) and lalach (greed), constantly bleed into one another. Ali Fazal becomes a Dharmendra-type vulnerable brute from the heartland whose violence is not calculated but an emotional tempest fuelled by raw passion. As Munna, Divyendu gets the best punchlines but has the craft to showcase the vulnerable side of an unhinged monster.

Unlike the dialogues, the songs and the sound design take time to grow on you. With over three hours of runtime, some of the desert sequences in the second half feel stretched, but in a post-Dhurandhar world, filmmakers are eager to indulge, knowing that telling the story in more than one installment is no longer a box office risk. Overall, it is an engaging experiment. Next, one would like to see Srikant Tiwari on a Family trip!

Mirzapur The Movie is currently running in theatres.

Dulquer Salmaan-starrer squanders a winning idea

Malayalam

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Grabbing an audience by the collar and taking them along the way is no easy task. In I'm Game, Nahas Hidayath had an idea that could do just that, though Hollywood has dabbled with similar themes before. But unfortunately, the filmmaker holds on to his fascinating concept for only a while before loosening his grip and veering off into familiar narrative patterns.

Dan John (Dulquer Salmaan), a spoilt child of a rich family, runs a company just as his father wished, but his heart lies in gambling like there is no tomorrow. Despite his wealthy background, his gambling habit leaves him neck-deep in debt.



But something bizarre happens to him, changing his life's trajectory, as well as that of quite a few others.

For Dulquer Salmaan, making his appearance in Malayalam cinema after a while, this was a perfect comeback opportunity, with his character having immense scope for

humour and action. The film does offer them for a while before getting derailed.

Nahas Hidayath debuted with RDX, a film with a bare-minimum story that gave the audience the emotional need to root for the three protagonists during the lengthy

action sequences. However, in I'm Game, despite the multiple story threads and ideas, everything happens at a distance, with the audience remaining untouched by what happens to any of the characters. This also makes the slickly edited and shot action sequences feel a bit stretched after a point.

One of the strangest writing decisions screenwriters Sajeer Baba, Ismail Aboobacker and Bilal Moidu make is the lengthy flashback story revolving around betting in a major cricket league. What could have been told in a few cleverly shot scenes is presented as a full-blown narrative. With an over-melodramatic romance also thrown in the mix, the core supernatural story takes a backseat, and Dulquer's character disappears from the screen for quite a long time. The film never really recovers

Film: I'm Game

Direction: Nahas Hidayath

Starring: Dulquer Salmaan, Kayadu Lohar, Mysskin, Samyuktha Viswanathan, Vinay Forrt, Anthony 'Pepe' Varghese, Kathir

Storyline: The life of a gambler, neck-deep in debts, changes after a bizarre event.

Runtime: 174 minutes

from the dip it suffers during this phase, where we are made to wait till the flashback meanders to a predictable end.

The hope that things would change for the better after the extended flashback goes in vain as the writers let go of the interesting core concept and focus on a run-of-the-mill revenge story. In the end, the only real creative spark was in the supernatural idea, with a lot of generic elements woven around it. Human greed, the behavioural change of a spoilt rich kid, and the corrosive influence of money on sports are left unexplored after they are briefly addressed.

In I'm Game, Nahas Hidayath loses the bird in his hand, chasing two in the bushes.

I'm Game is currently running in cinemas.

Onslaught

Director: Adam Wingard

Cast: Adria Arjona, Dan Stevens, Eric Wareheim, Reginald VelJohnson, Michael Biehn, Alex Pereira, Drew Starkey, Rebecca Hall

Runtime: 92 minutes

Storyline: A sniper has to protect her daughter from genetically enhanced super soldiers

A lean, mean fighting machine

English

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After heavy-duty nostalgia thanks to *The Magic Faraway Tree*, here comes another film reminding one of a no-frills actioner from the '80s. The fact that instead of a muscled, testosterone-driven protagonist, we have a sharp-shooting woman as the lead in Adam Wingard's *Onslaught*, keeps things interesting.

There are super soldiers, a mad scientist doing all sorts of dreadful experiments while in thrall to his wife, a blond assassin, and a sniper with PTSD in this lean, action-packed film.

Celeste (*Andor*'s Adria Arjona) lives in a trailer park on the edge of the desert in New Mexico. She was a sniper in the Army and when we first meet her she is practicing shooting at a line of jack-o'-lanterns perched on a fence. She has some trouble steadying her hand as she is visited by flashbacks of combat in an

arid area against a graffiti-strewn wall.

We then move to the sterile quarters of Dr. Hans Kammler (Dan Stevens) as he has breakfast with his wife, Hanna (Rebecca Hall). A chopper comes to take Hans to a secret military facility where he is developing genetically enhanced super soldiers who are programmed to keep killing until no one is left alive.

The soldiers were all terrible people when they were alive and after they died have been commandeered by the good doctor for his gruesome experiments. The trial naturally goes terribly wrong and suddenly the three killing machines are running loose shooting up gas stations before heading for the trailer park.

The movie does not explain exactly why the soldiers go rogue because according to Hans they shut down once everyone is killed. Celeste's ex-husband

has some urgent business to attend to and drops off their daughter, Daisy (Blake Kennedy) with her even though it is not her weekend with Daisy. The composed little girl immediately puts on a soothing podcast and starts doing the dishes that are piled high in the sink even as her parents quarrel.

And then the seemingly unstoppable soldiers attack the trailer park and all hell breaks loose. Hot on the heels of the soldiers is a blond and beautiful black ops clean-up man, Cyrus (Drew Starkey) who is told to protect the "work".

Onslaught has the economy of an '80s action movie, featuring masked, remorseless killers with glittering eyes riding a huge rig reminiscent of early James Cameron films and so it is no surprise to see Michael Biehn (Kyle Reese from *The Terminator*) popping up as another shady government official. Celeste's rough and ready

bandana to keep the blood out of her eyes does remind one of Rambo.

Stevens has the maximum fun as the completely cowed doctor while Arjona gives a spirited performance as the mama bear who will do anything to protect her cub. Director Adam Wingard and his long-time collaborator, Simon Barrett have fashioned a spare, superfast movie, that is definitely not short on blood-thirsty, charged action sequences.

After directing two Godzilla blockbusters, Wingard has been quoted as saying, "I felt like I needed to do a story that solidified what my style was as a filmmaker, and this is it," and it is a wholly welcome change as is Karel Gott's German cover of The Rolling Stones' 'Paint It, Black'.

Onslaught is currently running in theatres

Snippets



Asha Bhosle's final playback song unveiled

Asha Bhosle's final playback song from upcoming film, *Om Ka Hari*, was unveiled by the makers on the occasion of the singer's birth anniversary. Titled 'Ae Meri Zindagi, Tu Chupi Hain Kahan', the music video shows glimpses of the song's recording featuring the legendary singer. The song was unveiled as part of the film's album launch which consists of songs sung by Amit Kumar, Paresh Pahuja and Raghubir Yadav. 'Ae Meri Zindagi, Tu Chupi Hain Kahan' has been composed by Rajieve Sarang and written by Pradeep Sharma Khuro. The song carries an old school charm with the voice of Asha adding a charming emotional flavour. *Om Ka Hari* is directed by Harish Vyas and also stars Soni Razdan and Anshuman Jha in pivotal roles. *Om Ka Hari* is scheduled to be released in theatres on September 18.



Ekadesham to premiere at Filmfest Aachen

Malayalam filmmaker Don Palathara's new film, *Ekadesham*, will premiere at Filmfest Aachen 2026 in Germany. The film has been selected for the competition section at the festival, which will be held from September 23 to 27. *Ekadesham* (titled *The Uncertainty Principle* in English) stars Roshan Mathew, Jithin Puthenchery, Divya Prabha, Aarsha Baiju and filmmaker-editor Mahesh Narayanan. A statement issued by the team says that the narrative is set in Kochi and zooms in on the lives of a group of young people whose lives revolve around cinema, even as they deal with unstable and uncertain careers and relationships.



Picasso first look revealed

The title and first look of the collaboration between Kannada superstar Shivarajkumar and youngster Abishan Jeevinth have been unveiled. The movie is titled *Picasso*. The first look of the movie was released by actor-director Rishab Shetty. Presented by Drama Company, the film is directed by debutant Gowtham Sivaraman. The first look of *Picasso* shows Shivarajkumar and Abishan in traditional white attire, offering a mischievous look. Abishan, who debuted as a director with the hit *Tourist Family*, tasted success as an actor in *With Love*. Shivarajkumar was last seen in *Peddi*, starring Ram Charan. Leon James has composed the music for *Picasso*. Pragadeesh Prabhu has handled cinematography, while Suresh is the editor.



Where childhood still grows

A charming adaptation of Enid Blyton's *Faraway Tree* stories with an excellent cast and delightful production design, *The Magic Faraway Tree* offers a chance to slide down the Slippery Slip and revisit the weird and wonderful lands atop the tree

English

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As children, we devoured Enid Blyton's *Faraway Tree* stories and dreamt of visiting the different lands that appeared at the top of the Faraway Tree in the middle of the Enchanted Wood.

We wholeheartedly believed in Moonface's round room with curved furniture, and the Slippery Slip, Mr Watzisname, who found out his name in the Land of Secrets and promptly forgot it, and dear Saucepan Man who caused a great deal of confusion.

The descriptions of food, from Google (yes, Blyton imagined it in 1939, long before it was a verb), buns with sherbet-filled currants to the toffee shocks that grew as you ate them till they exploded, kicked off rather disastrous kitchen experiments.

When news of an adaptation broke, one was cautiously optimistic, wondering if the filmmaker's imagination would

The Magic Faraway Tree

Director: Ben Gregor

Starring: Andrew Garfield, Claire Foy, Nonso Anozie, Nicola Coughlan, Jessica Gunning, Jennifer Saunders, Rebecca Ferguson

Runtime: 110 minutes

Storyline: A family moves to the country and discovers the importance of connection, imagination and magic

mesh with our own. *The Magic Faraway Tree*, while not being a slavish adaptation of the books, is very much a spiritual reimagining of the series. There is a gentle humour, vivid imagination and a quiet wonder to the film that makes it irresistible.

Tim (Andrew Garfield) and Polly (Claire Foy) Thompson move to the country with their three children, Beth (Delilah Bennett-Cardy), Joe (Phoenix Laroche), and Fran (Billie Gadsdon). While Beth and Joe are addicted to their screens, Fran is the dreamer who rarely speaks. Polly is an inventor who creates a smart fridge (with Judi Dench's voice) but resigns when she learns of the secret cameras placed on the fridge to spy on people.

Tim says it is the perfect time to leave for the country, and though the children are resistant at first, once Fran discovers a whole new world in the Enchanted Wood, the others join in as well.

The cast draws us into the magical world with their spirited performances. Garfield and Foy are the kind of storybook parents any child would love. Nicola Coughlan is delightful as the non-winged fairy, Silky, while Rebecca Ferguson (quite a change from *Silo's* Jules to be sure!) is a hoot as Dame Snap

singing 'Teddy Bear's Picnic'.

There are departures from the book, as expected, and Moonface (Nonso Anozie) is not how I imagined him, though Saucepan Man (Dustin Demri-Burns) is exactly right. The Slippery Slip is not a hole in Moonface's floor, but going down it seems to be ripping good fun. Having what one imagined brought to life exactly would have been rather spooky, no?

The palette is not overtly twee, comfortably walking the line between reality and full-blown fantasy with fairy dust and beautiful towering trees. There are nice touches such as a talking toothbrush warning against cavities in the Land of Goodies and Dame Snap explaining that she used to be called Dame Slap and that her name changed because she cannot slap her students, much like in the later editions of the books where Dame Slap's name was changed to Snap.

While there is enough to engage and delight Blyton devotees, the film also has enough whimsy and charm to welcome people unfamiliar with the books. And there are going to be sequels!

The Magic Faraway Tree is currently running in theatres